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A PRACTICE GUIDE FROM THE HUSH ROOM

Lectio *Divina.*

Sacred Reading · The Word read as a living voice.



Reading Scripture not for information, but for encounter. Slowly. Listening. As though God Himself were speaking — because, in fact, He is.

"We read under the eye of God until the heart is touched and leaps to flame."

Abbot Marmion · 6th century Benedictine

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The world says rush. God says hush.

THE PRACTICE

Why we read this way.

Most of the reading we do is for information. We scan, skim, extract the point, move on. We read books, articles, messages, feeds — fast and forward. This is appropriate for most of life.

But Scripture is not most of life. The Word is alive. When we read it the way we read everything else, we miss what is actually happening — God is speaking, and we are racing past.

Lectio Divina — Latin for sacred reading — is the ancient Christian practice of reading Scripture slowly enough that God can be heard. It does not require special training. It does not require a theology degree. It only requires that we slow down.

Bible is not merely to inform — but to transform.

Eugene Peterson called Scripture intestinal — meant to be eaten, not just read. Mary of Bethany sat at Jesus' feet and hung on every word. This is not a technique. This is a posture: an undivided attention, given to a Voice we trust.

Remember: it is not hasty reading but serious meditation on holy and heavenly truths that makes them prove sweet and profitable to the soul. It is not the bee's mere touching of the flower that gathers honey — but her abiding for a time on the flower that draws out the sweet.

Thomas Brooks · 17th century

THE FOUR MOVEMENTS

The classical pattern, in plain language.

Lectio Divina has been practised in this four-fold rhythm since at least the sixth century. The Latin names — Lectio, Meditatio, Oratio, Contemplatio — translate simply: Read, Reflect, Respond, Rest. Twenty to forty-five minutes is enough.

i. Lectio

Read.

Choose a short passage — eight to twelve verses, no more. The Psalms work beautifully. So do the Gospels. Read it slowly, aloud if you can. Read it twice.

On the second reading, listen for a single word, phrase, image, or idea that arrests you — that catches, snags, lights up. Don't analyse why. Just notice it. Underline it. Write it down.

ii. Meditatio

Reflect.

Stay with the word that arrested you. Roll it around. Wonder about it. What does it touch in you — a memory, an ache, a hope, a question? Why this word, and not another?

This is not study. This is conversation. The word that arrested you is an invitation. The Spirit is already in the room.

iii. Oratio

Respond.

Speak to God, honestly, about what you have noticed. Out loud or silently. In gratitude, in grief, in confusion, in joy. If a question rises, ask it directly. If you have nothing to say, say that.

You may want to journal here. A sentence is enough. The point is not to produce a record — the point is to respond.

iv. Contemplatio

Rest.

Stop talking. Stop thinking. Sit. Breathe. Receive.

This is the strangest of the four movements for many of us. Nothing is required of you here. You have read, reflected, responded — now simply rest in the presence of the One who has been with you the whole time. Five minutes is enough. Twenty is a gift.

A SECOND WAY IN

Four questions, when the four movements feel abstract.

If the Latin pattern feels cumbersome, try this simpler version. Read your passage twice, slowly. Then ask, in turn:

1. The Text

What does the text say?

What is actually here? Read it as though you've never seen it before. Notice details. Resist your assumptions about what it means.

2. *The Address*

What does the text say to me?

Where does this passage land in your life — today, this week, this season? What does it touch?

3. *The Response*

What do I say to God about this text?

Speak. Honestly. Even if it's resistance, doubt, or anger — God can handle the truth. The Psalms model this for us.

4. *The Difference*

What difference will this text make in my life?

Not a goal-list. Just a noticing. What is one small way this Word might shape your day, your week, your way of seeing?

A note: Lectio Divina is not Bible study. It is not exegesis. Both are good — but this is something different. Here, the goal is not to understand the passage but to be encountered by the One who speaks through it. If you find yourself running to a commentary mid-prayer, smile, set it aside, and return.

WHERE TO BEGIN

Passages that have nourished pilgrims before you.

If you don't know where to start, try one of these. They have been the daily bread of contemplatives for centuries:

Psalm 23 *The Lord is my shepherd.*

Psalm 46 *Be still, and know that I am God.*

Psalm 139 *Search me, O God, and know my heart.*

Isaiah 30:15–18 *In returning and rest you shall be saved.*

Matthew 11:28–30 *Come to me, all who are weary.*

Luke 10:38–42 *Mary chose the better part.*

Luke 15:11–32 *While he was still a long way off, his father saw him.*

John 15:1–11 *Abide in me, as I abide in you.*

When we submit our lives to what we read in Scripture, we find we are not being led to see God in our stories — but our stories in God's. God is the larger context and plot in which our stories find themselves.

Eugene Peterson · Eat This Book

A blessing as you begin.

*May the Word that has nourished saints for two thousand years
find its way into the marrow of your bones.
May you read slowly enough to hear the Voice
that has been speaking your name
since before you were born.*

The Father waits. The Son welcomes. The Spirit moves.